



Sheep licked salt

David Nyzio's "Smoke and Mirrors" exhibition contained a number of sculptures made with the help of animals <https://digit.in/sep18-66-1>



Attracted to Light

This artwork captures the motion of moths through the air, then translates it to a 3D printed sculpture <https://digit.in/sep18-66-2>

A Satin Bowerbird in its nest, where it has collected and arranged small pieces of blue plastic rubbish



Credit: Joseph C Boone

THE ARTISTIC SKILLS OF ANIMALS

Art has long been thought of as something only humans can produce, but researchers are finding out that animals might have the emotional complexity for artistic expression as well

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here is no commonly agreed upon definition of what exactly art is. Creativity and aesthetic appeal are commonly accepted aspects of art. While art is about beauty, artists also enjoy the commercial benefits of

creating art. When considering the artistic abilities of animals, the definition for what is art to an animal might be completely different. For example, researchers may not consider songs of birds as music, because they do not follow human scales. There are other reasons why songs of birds, while known to be aesthetically pleasing, are not considered art. Most songbirds do not sit down and compose their own music. They learn

it from the previous generations. However, there is an exception - the Lyrebird. This species of bird listens to the songs in its environment, and remixes them into a new song, which it sings to attract mates. At times, the bird incorporates sounds of human activity into its songs as well - chain-saws or human made music.

An investigation into the vocalisations of the Australian magpie showed that the bird would sing even when they are alone. These songs cannot be explained by any other function - either of reproduction or territorial defense. The magpie is singing purely as a form of self expression. Additionally, the magpies attach a signature closing phrase, that is unique to each individual. Researchers have also found evidence to suggest that the ever mutating songs of the humpback whale is driven by a creative process - rather than constrained by any function.

ANIMAL SCULPTORS

David Nyzio is an American artist who showcased a number of artwork created with the help of animals in his show titled "Smoke and Mirrors". An arch was crafted using stumps that had been chewed by beavers. There were also fifteen pieces of salt that had been licked by sheep which resulted in various shapes and forms.

A number of artists have collaborated with the industrious bees to create sculptures. Aganetha Dyck, a Canadian artist, makes bees build hives around porcelain figurines and sports equipment in apiaries. For his "Yuansu Project" exhibition, Ren Ri, a Chinese "biomedia" artist showcased a number of sculptures created with the help of bees. The process involved carefully placing the queen bee at a strategic location, and then moving her so the bees would build around the queen. Tomas Libertiny, another artist who uses bees as a 3D printer, has produced hives in the form of vases. The bees were introduced inside wooden scaffolds of the requisite shape. Once the hive was constructed, the scaffolds were removed. The process took